

EYEWITNESS 1960s

Tunnel Rat

Ruben Dominguez was trained to be a special electronic devices technician, but upon arrival in Vietnam, was given a new mission. Along with seven other “thin, small men” from his company, he was selected to infiltrate the elaborate underground networks of the Viet Cong as a tunnel rat. Dominguez was known as Ghost for his ability to explore the tunnels undetected.

Many tunnels were rigged with explosives and trip wires, but Dominguez claims the worst thing about the tunnels was the bugs, which would eat you alive. On one occasion he was sent down into a deep, complex hole, with very little room to move. Inside it was dark and smelled like urine and feces. He crawled along until he had almost reached the end and he was able to straighten up a little. He thought he was walking through water—the flashlights tunnel rats were given were such poor quality it was difficult to see. There was the sound of digging up ahead and, as the light improved, a medical facility of some sort came into view.

“It wasn’t water, it was what was left of the bodies ... I got out of there.”

US ARMY TUNNEL RAT RUBEN “GHOST” DOMINGUEZ, INTERVIEWED BY *VIETNAM VETERAN NEWS*, SEPTEMBER 2015